

hustling, and other economically marginalized activities. Thus, from the outset of the post-World War II gay rights movement, transgender practices and identities marked communal boundaries between the normative and the transgressive.

One particular archival discovery seemed so perfectly attuned to all my research motivations, however, and so seemingly significant yet almost entirely unknown, that I initially questioned whether it could possibly be true. In the centerfold of the program for the first Gay Pride Parade in San Francisco, held in 1972, I found a description of a 1966 riot in San Francisco's Tenderloin District, in which drag queens and gay hustlers banded together at a popular late-night hangout called Gene Compton's Cafeteria to fight back against police harassment and social oppression. The key text reads as follows:

In the streets of the Tenderloin, at Turk and Taylor on a hot August night in 1966, Gays rose up angry at the constant police harassment of the drag queens by the police. It had to be the first ever recorded violence by Gays against police anywhere. For on that evening when the SFPD paddy wagon drove up to make their "usual" sweeps of the streets, Gays this time did not go willingly. It began when the police came into a cafeteria, still located there at Turk and Taylor, Compton's, to do their usual job of hassling the drag-queens and hair-fairies and hustlers setting at the table. This was with the permission of management, of course. But when the police grabbed the arm of one of the transvestites, he threw his cup of coffee in the cop's face, and with that, cups, saucers, and trays began flying around the place, and all directed at the police. They retreated outside until reinforcements arrived, and the Compton's management ordered the place closed, and with that, the Gays began breaking out every window in the place, and as they ran outside to escape the breaking glass, the police tried to grab them and throw them into the paddy wagon, but they found this no easy task for Gays began hitting them "below the belt" and drag-queens smashing them in the face with their extremely heavy purses. A police car had every window broken, a newspaper shack outside the cafeteria was burned to the ground, and general havoc was raised that night in the Tenderloin. The next night drag-queens, hair-fairies, conservative Gays, and hustlers joined in a picket of the cafeteria, which would not allow drags back in again. It ended with the newly installed plate glass windows once more being smashed. The Police Community Relations Unit began mediating the conflict, which was never fully re-

solved, which ended in a group called VANGUARD being formed of the street peoples and a lesbian group of street people being formed called the STREET ORPHANS, both of which later became the old GAY LIBERATION FRONT in San Francisco, and is today called the GAY ACTIVISTS ALLIANCE.<sup>12</sup>

The story seemed important in several respects. First, what reportedly happened at Compton's Cafeteria bore obvious similarities to the famous Stonewall uprising in New York in 1969, where the militant phase of gay liberation is commonly supposed to have begun, but reputedly preceded it by three years. How the San Francisco gay activist community positioned the Compton's story vis-à-vis Stonewall in their first commemorative Gay Pride Parade was clearly intended as an early revisionist account of gay liberation history. Furthermore, the inciting incident of the riot was described as an act of antitransgender discrimination, rather than an act of discrimination against sexual orientation.

At the time I came across this source in 1995, the role of drag queens in the Stonewall riots had become a site of conflict between transgender and normative gay/lesbian histories—transgender activists pointed to the act of mythologizing Stonewall as the “birth” of gay liberation as a homonormative co-optation of gender queer resistance, while homonormative gay and lesbian commentators tended to downplay the significance of antidrag oppression at Stonewall—and whatever I could learn about the Compton's incident would certainly inform that debate. The 1972 document also related a genealogy of gay liberation activism at odds with the normative accounts—one rooted in the socioeconomics of the multiethnic Tenderloin sex-work ghetto rather than in campus-based activism oriented toward countercultural white youth of middle-class origin. For all these reasons, the Compton's Cafeteria riot became a central focus of my research into San Francisco's transgender history and its intersectional relationship to the history of gay and lesbian communities.

Although the 1972 document proved factually inaccurate in several particulars (the picketing happened before the riot, for example), I was ultimately able to verify its basic account of the Compton's Cafeteria riot and to situate that event in a history of transgender community formation and politicization that both complemented and contested homonormative gay and lesbian history. Most important, I was able to connect the location and timing of the riot to social, political, geographical, and historical circumstances in San Francisco in ways that the Stonewall story had never connected gay

liberation discourse to similar circumstances in New York—thereby opening up new ways to think about the relationship between identity politics and broader material conditions. The 1966 riot at Compton's Cafeteria took place at the intersection of several broad social issues that continue to be of concern today, such as discriminatory policing practices in minority communities, the lack of minority access to appropriate health care, elitist urban land-use policies, the unsettling domestic consequences of foreign wars, and civil rights campaigns that aim to expand individual liberties and social tolerance on matters of sexuality and gender.<sup>13</sup>

#### Homonormative Disciplinarity

Although the history of the Compton's Cafeteria riot provides a productive point of critique and revision for homonormative accounts of the recent history of sexual identity communities and movements, most knowledge of this event has circulated through works of public history (most notably the 2005 public television documentary *Screaming Queens: The Riot at Compton's Cafeteria*), work by nonacademic writers, and in community-based publications, rather than through professional academic channels.<sup>14</sup> In those few instances in which this history has been examined in peer reviewed journals, the articles have been placed, as this one has been, in sections of the journals set aside for uses other than feature articles. In the one instance where this has not been the case, the article was written by another (nontransgendered) scholar who interviewed me and made use of primary source documents I directed her to, in order to relate the Compton's Cafeteria riot to her own research interest in the sociology of historical memory.<sup>15</sup>

I point this out not as a complaint—it was my own decision to pursue the public history dissemination of my research findings; I actually guest-edited a journal issue that put my own research into the back matter and anonymized my authorship, and I have eagerly collaborated with other scholars who have never failed to accurately and appropriately cite the use of my research in their own projects. My aim, rather, is to call needed attention to the micropolitical practices through which the radical implications of transgender knowledges can become marginalized. Even in contexts such as this special homonormativities issue of *Radical History Review*, which explicitly called for transgender scholarship that could generate “new analytical frameworks for talking about lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer history that expand and challenge current models of identity and community formation as well as models of political and cultural resistance,” transgender knowl-

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edges are far too easily subjugated to what Michel Foucault once called "the  
hierarchies of erudition."<sup>16</sup>

In my original abstract for this issue, I proposed not only to recount the  
little-known history of the Compton's Cafeteria riot but also to call attention  
to the multiple normativizing frames of reference that kept the Compton's  
story "hidden in plain sight" for so long—the confluence of class, race, and  
gender considerations, as well as the homonormative gaze that did not con-  
struct transgender subjects, actions, embodiments, or intentions as the ob-  
jects of its desire. I wanted, too, to make methodologically explicit the critical  
role of embodied difference in the practice of archival research.

As a range of new scholarship on the recent so-called archival turn in the  
humanities begins to make evident, embodiment—that contingent accom-  
plishment through which the histories of our identities become invested in  
our corporeal space—not only animates the research query but modulates  
access to the archive in both its physical and its intellectual arrangement.  
Discussing how my transsexual embodiment figured into reading a gay and  
lesbian archive against the grain served the larger purpose of calling critical  
attention to homonormative constructions of knowledge embedded in the  
content and organization of the archive itself. My goal was to offer a radical  
critique not just of historiography but of the political epistemology of histori-  
cal knowledge production.

Because the tone of what I proposed was deemed "personal," due to how  
I situated my own research activities as part of the narrative, and because, I  
suspect, I tend to work outside the academy, I was invited to contribute an  
essay to either the "Reflections" or "Public History" section of *Radical His-*  
*tory Review*, rather than a feature article. I felt some reservations in doing so  
because my intent had been to do something else. "Reflections" are not as  
intellectually rigorous as the documented arguments expected in feature ar-  
ticles, and "Public History," as distinguished from what academic historians  
do, can come off as a form of popularization in which knowledge produced  
by specialists is transmitted to the consuming masses through less intellectu-  
ally accomplished intermediaries. The journal's own division of knowledge  
into "less formal" and "more formal" categories, and the positioning of my  
work within this two-tiered economy, would replicate the very hierarchies I  
had set out to critique by containing what I had to say within a structurally  
less legitimated space.

The most basic act of normativizing disciplinarity at work here is not di-  
rectly related to the increasingly comfortable fit between gender-normative  
homosexuality and neoliberal policy. It is rooted in a more fundamental and